



Khushboo Ranka and Vinay Shukla



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Filmed during the 2020 Delhi riots and the anti-CAA (Citizenship Amendment Act) protests, Sen's documentary gives one the feeling that the capital is hurtling towards an apocalypse, but, in the end, what it really seems to document is the slow death of idealism in today's India.

SHOT TO FAME
(Clockwise from left) Stills from *Writing With Fire*, *An Insignificant Man* and *All That Breathes*

Writing With Fire almost seems like a counterpoint. It follows the lives of Dalit women working for *Khabar Lahariya*, a rural news network in Uttar Pradesh. "We met them in 2015—at an interesting point in their lives. After 14 years of being a newspaper, they were thinking of transitioning into digital. And most women in the reporting team had never touched a smartphone before," says Thomas. To imagine themselves as a digital force at that point, only "spoke of the resilience, acumen and chutzpah of these women".

Even before the laurels of the last few years, India's non-fiction space had been brimming with potential. Nisha Pahuja's *The World Before Her* (2012), Deepti Kakkar's *Katiyabaaz* (2013), Khushboo Ranka and Vinay Shukla's *An Insignificant Man* (2017) released in theatres and were acclaimed. Ranka is part of an acclerator called Indian Docs along with filmmakers Vinay Shukla, Shaunak Sen and Archana Phadke. They hope to help promising documentary projects with seed capital. "It's the most difficult money to raise, but it also ensures the most help for a filmmaker starting out," says Ranka. Indian Docs has two primary objectives—ensure more quality and speed up the process of bringing more films into active development.

Shukla says while political films are the need of the hour, we shouldn't burden non-fiction films by only associating them with politics/ activism. "*The Cinema Travellers* (2016) and shows like *Indian Matchmaking* (2020) are also examples of globally successful Indian non-fiction," he says. One can almost imagine the glee on Ranka's face when she speaks of how we have been looking to mainstream industries for an Oscar contender, but a documentary has made it instead. ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee

NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

MUST-SEE SOUTH ASIAN DOCUMENTARIES

GHOSTS OF AFGHANISTAN (2021)

Afghanistan

Julian Sher's documentary follows Canadian journalist Graeme Smith as he offers a first-hand account of the Taliban takeover and how NATO failed Afghanistan and its women.



LONG PERIOD OF PERSECUTION (2019)

Bangladesh

Proshoon Rahman's documentary is one of the most thorough pieces of journalism on the Rohingya refugees, who were forced to flee Myanmar following a campaign of ethnic cleansing.



SHOWGIRLS OF PAKISTAN (2020)

Pakistan

The toast of IDFA 2020, Saad Khan's documentary puts Pakistan's *mujra* culture under the microscope. The film examines how three dancers pursue their vocation while battling death threats.

